Capstone: prepare a customer discovery summary

Prepare a discovery summary for a fictional online retailer. Bring together customer research, cloud needs, discovery questions, sales materials and CRM-style notes. The final project is the practical task inside this capstone activity.

You are an entry-level sales associate in a cloud sales organisation. Your manager wants a short discovery summary before the team's first customer meeting. Use the supplied case as your research source. You do not need to find this fictional company online, open a cloud account or build a technical solution.

This is practice, with a self-review and a worked example. Your written responses are not submitted or automatically graded. The separate final course quiz remains the course's graded assessment.

Allow about 45 minutes. Complete the five tasks, check your reasoning, then compare with the worked example. Write in your own document or the supplied workbook. Use the Opportunities tab. Keep a copy of your work; it is not submitted for grading.

Company and customers

Sto Lat Select is a fictional, mid-sized e-commerce retailer founded in 2016. It sells lifestyle and home goods, including home decor, small appliances and personalised accessories. It has about 250 employees, no physical shops, and customers in the United States, Canada and parts of Western Europe. It plans to expand internationally.

How it operates

All sales go through its website. A small engineering team maintains on-premises servers and connects the storefront to email marketing, customer analytics, payments, inventory and order-management tools. Marketing uses personalised recommendations, email campaigns, seasonal promotions and social advertising. Customer support uses separate chat, tracking and feedback systems.

Peak traffic

Promotions, holiday shopping and influencer campaigns cause traffic spikes. The current infrastructure cannot increase capacity quickly. The case reports slower pages, checkout delays, occasional outages and additional work on patching and capacity management. The case does not quantify the frequency, cost or duration of those problems.

Customer information

Customer data is spread across five or more systems. Profiles are inconsistent, staff make manual exports, and personalisation is limited. Leadership wants a clearer view of customers and buying behaviour. Teams also find it difficult to report on customer value, repeat purchases, product recommendations and inventory needs.

Growth and protection

International expansion brings additional data-protection, payment-security and regional compliance questions. The team is concerned about patching, access controls, sensitive data and audit records. Cloud adoption alone would not establish compliance; the team would need to investigate responsibilities and controls.

Priorities and unknowns

Over the next 12–18 months, leadership wants more reliable website performance, better customer insights, less maintenance work and support for safe growth. It is exploring cloud options but has not started a formal evaluation. The case gives no confirmed budget, decision maker, migration deadline, agreed service choice or measured savings. Treat those as questions, not facts.

Cloud capability reference

Traffic peaks and slow pages

Capacity that can increase or decrease with demand; load balancing and availability options. Investigate workload, performance targets and application design.

Fragmented customer information

Data integration, managed storage and analytics capabilities. Investigate data quality, access and consent before proposing consolidation.

Backup and recovery needs

Backup, storage redundancy and disaster-recovery options. Establish recovery needs and responsibilities; do not assume a backup policy exists.

Security and access concerns

Encryption, identity and access management, monitoring and audit capabilities. Identify requirements and shared responsibilities with a technical colleague.

Maintenance and cost concerns

Managed services and usage-based charging may change the work and costs involved. Confirm usage, migration effort and support needs before claiming savings.

Profile the customer

Write one or two short paragraphs describing Sto Lat Select's operations, digital presence and main challenges. Use only facts supplied in the case. Explain why those facts matter for the first customer conversation.

Workbook mapping: Company profile and Needs / Challenges

- I have described the online-only business and its customers.
- I have connected two or more case facts to discovery priorities.
- I have not invented customer research, figures or decision makers.

Identify possible cloud needs

Choose two or three needs grounded in the case. For each, connect a customer problem to a possible cloud capability and explain what you would need to confirm. You are preparing for discovery, not selecting a provider or designing architecture.

Workbook mapping: Needs / Challenges and Win plan summary

- Each need comes from the supplied case.
- I have explained the business relevance of a possible capability.
- I have named a question or limitation instead of guaranteeing a result.

Prepare the conversation

Write three to five open discovery questions. Ask about the customer's priorities, impact, current approach and readiness. Give the customer room to explain rather than steering them to a particular product.

Workbook mapping: Win plan summary

- My questions invite an explanation rather than a yes/no answer.
- They connect to the customer's actual situation.
- They help clarify unknowns without assuming an agreed solution.

Choose useful sales materials

Choose two or three of the material types below. Explain who needs each one, what it should help them do, and why it fits this stage of the conversation. These are planning descriptions, not claims that a finished customer-specific document already exists.

Workbook mapping: Notes

- I have identified the audience and purpose of each material.
- I have linked each choice to a case need.
- I have kept internal preparation materials distinct from customer-facing content.

Leave a usable handover

Bring your work into a concise CRM-style handover. Include the company, needs and challenges, important unknowns, discovery questions, suitable materials and a realistic next action. You can write here or use the downloadable workbook's Opportunities tab. Unused fields may remain blank or N/A; record unconfirmed information as unknown.

Workbook mapping: Needs / Challenges; Internal alignment plan; Win plan summary; Next steps; Notes

- A colleague can distinguish supplied facts from possible explanations and proposed actions.
- The handover includes questions and an achievable next step.
- I have kept budget, authority and timing unknown where the case provides no confirmation.

Sales material types

Customer engagement cloud one-pager

Customer stakeholders: A short overview linking cloud capabilities to customer needs. Use it to frame a discussion, while making clear which benefits still need investigation.

Cloud migration objection-handling guide

The sales team: An internal preparation tool for questions about costs, disruption, data protection and responsibilities. Use it to plan questions and involve a technical colleague where needed.

Analytics and data capabilities quick-reference sheet

The sales team: A concise reference to capabilities, questions and limits. Use it to check terminology and prepare accurate follow-up; it is not a technical design or a customer-specific promise.

Self-review questions

1. Which details belong in the company profile? Select two.

- A. Its online-only sales model and digital marketing activity.
- B. An estimated technology budget that is not given in the case.
- C. Its reported peak-traffic and fragmented-data problems.
- D. A named decision maker inferred from the company's size.

2. Why identify possible cloud needs before choosing a service?

- A. To make a product shortlist before discussing customer priorities.
- B. To connect a capability to a business problem and identify what still needs confirming.
- C. To replace the technical colleague's later requirements review.
- D. To turn the customer's growth plans into a confirmed migration commitment.

3. Which capabilities are worth investigating for promotion-related traffic problems? Select two.

- A. Capacity that can adjust as demand changes.
- B. A fixed capacity commitment chosen without traffic information.
- C. Suitable availability and load-balancing options.
- D. A customer analytics report used as the sole reliability measure.

4. What should the team clarify before recommending customer-data consolidation?

- A. Whether the company's employee count will stay exactly the same.
- B. Which provider's branding should appear on the recommendation.
- C. Whether every customer record can be retained indefinitely.
- D. Which data people need, who owns it, its quality and the access requirements.

5. Which questions support open discovery? Select two.

- A. Would you like us to select a cloud package now?
- B. Which reporting difficulty has the greatest effect on your team's decisions?
- C. What concerns would you need addressed before evaluating a change?

- D. Can we assume the engineering lead has already approved the move?

6. Which material uses fit an early discovery conversation? Select two.

- A. A full implementation proposal presented as already approved.
- B. An internal objection-handling guide for preparing questions about disruption and cost.
- C. A customer-specific price guarantee based on no usage information.
- D. A capabilities quick-reference sheet for preparing accurate follow-up questions.

7. What is the main purpose of the CRM-style handover?

- A. To turn possible cloud opportunities into confirmed deal facts.
- B. To give a colleague usable context, known information, open questions and next actions.
- C. To replace the original case with a longer account history.
- D. To demonstrate that every available CRM column has been populated.

8. What should remain explicitly unconfirmed in this record? Select two.

- A. The company sells online.
- B. The customer's budget and decision authority.
- C. The case reports fragmented customer information.
- D. An agreed migration deadline and expected savings.

9. Which statement is suitably bounded for this stage?

- A. Managed services will remove the engineering team's operational responsibilities.
- B. Cloud adoption will establish the retailer's compliance with regional requirements.
- C. The team could investigate capacity and data capabilities, then validate fit and responsibilities.
- D. A provider can be selected because the case mentions international growth.

10. How should you use the worked example?

- A. Compare the reasoning with your own work, identify gaps and revise your handover.
- B. Copy its exact wording so every learner produces the same response.
- C. Treat its proposed actions as additional customer facts.
- D. Use it as proof that a real customer accepted the proposed cloud direction.

Self-review answers and feedback

Question 1: A, C

Correct. The sales model and reported problems are supplied case facts. Budget and decision authority remain unknown.

Revisit hint: Review Company and customers, Peak traffic and Priorities and unknowns. Separate supplied facts from assumptions.

Question 2: B

Correct. Discovery connects problems to possible capabilities while keeping requirements and assumptions open for confirmation.

Revisit hint: Review Identify possible cloud needs. Consider the distinction between discovery and an agreed recommendation.

Question 3: A, C

Correct. Elastic capacity and appropriate availability options are relevant to investigate. Their effectiveness depends on workload, design and requirements.

Revisit hint: Review the Traffic peaks and slow pages capability note. Ask which options address capacity and availability.

Question 4: D

Correct. Ownership, quality, access and intended use must be clarified before consolidation can be recommended.

Revisit hint: Review Customer information and the integration/analytics capability note. Consider what makes information usable and appropriate to share.

Question 5: B, C

Correct. These questions invite priorities and concerns. They do not presume approval or a product choice.

Revisit hint: Review Prepare the conversation. Look for questions that invite the customer's explanation without presuming a decision.

Question 6: B, D

Correct. Both references support preparation. They do not establish a final design, price or customer commitment.

Revisit hint: Review Choose useful sales materials. Match the stage of the conversation to the audience and purpose.

Question 7: B

Correct. A useful record helps the next colleague continue the work and distinguish facts, unknowns and actions.

Revisit hint: Review Leave a usable handover. Think about what the next colleague needs in order to continue responsibly.

Question 8: B, D

Correct. The case does not establish budget, authority, a migration deadline or savings. The sales model and data problems are provided.

Revisit hint: Review Priorities and unknowns. A growth-planning horizon is not automatically a migration commitment.

Question 9: C

Correct. The proposal is to investigate and validate. Responsibilities, compliance and service fit are not established by the case alone.

Revisit hint: Review the capability notes and Growth and protection. Distinguish a possible investigation from an established result.

Question 10: A

Correct. Different responses can be sound when they use the case accurately, explain their reasoning and preserve uncertainty.

Revisit hint: Review your task checklists. The example shows a possible response to a fictional case, rather than a customer-approved solution.

The worked examples below show one possible response. Compare their reasoning with your own work and preserve the difference between facts, unknowns and proposed actions.

Worked example: Profile the customer

Sto Lat Select is an online-only retailer of lifestyle and home goods with about 250 employees. Its website and digital marketing support all sales, so the traffic-related delays and occasional outages described in the case are relevant discovery topics.

Its customer information is spread across several systems and reporting requires manual work. Leadership is exploring cloud options to support growth, customer insights and more reliable operations. Budget, decision authority and a migration deadline have not yet been confirmed.

Worked example: Identify possible cloud needs

1. Website reliability during promotions: capacity that can adjust with demand and suitable availability options may help. Confirm traffic patterns, the application's constraints and acceptable interruption before making a recommendation.

2. Customer information and reporting: integration and analytics capabilities may help teams use consistent information. Confirm data ownership, quality, access and the reports people need.

3. Maintenance and protection: managed services, access controls and monitoring may support the engineering team. Clarify responsibilities, current effort and requirements; neither lower costs nor compliance is established by moving to cloud services.

Worked example: Prepare the conversation

What happens for customers and your team when a promotion causes a traffic spike?
How do different teams use customer information today, and where do inconsistencies cause the most difficulty?
Which improvement would matter most over the next year, and how would you judge its success?
What concerns would you want addressed before evaluating a change to your current systems?
Who would need to be involved in discussing the priorities, budget and next steps?

Worked example: Choose useful sales materials

Customer engagement cloud one-pager: prepare a customer-facing overview linking reliability and better customer information to possible capabilities. It can help stakeholders frame questions without presenting an approved solution.

Cloud migration objection-handling guide: use internally to prepare for concerns about disruption, cost and data protection. It should help the team plan a technical follow-up, not promise that concerns have been resolved.

Analytics and data capabilities quick-reference sheet: use internally to check terminology and prepare questions about fragmented customer information and reporting. Confirm any service-specific detail before sharing it.

Worked example: Leave a usable handover

Company: Sto Lat Select, an online-only home and lifestyle retailer with about 250 employees.
Needs / Challenges: peak-traffic delays and outages; inconsistent customer information; manual reporting; growing protection and maintenance demands.
Unknowns: impact measures, budget, decision authority, required controls and any migration deadline.
Internal alignment: prepare discovery questions about priorities and current systems; involve a technical colleague when requirements are clearer.
Possible direction: investigate elastic capacity, data integration and analytics, and managed-service options. No provider or architecture has been agreed.
Next step: prepare a discovery meeting and confirm who should attend. Agree responsibility and timing with the team rather than inventing customer commitments.
Notes: prepare a customer-facing one-pager and internal objection-handling and capabilities references. Keep the full question list with this record.

Keep your work and return

Retain your discovery summary and workbook. Review what you changed after comparing the example. Return to FutureLearn for the separate final course quiz and the showcasing-your-skills steps.